MEDICINES

# Managing your heart medicines

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

## What do your medicines do?

Heart medicines may help control blood pressure, manage cholesterol, or reduce the risk of blood clots. Your prescription depends on your condition. Ask your doctor or pharmacist what each medicine does. Keep taking medicines as prescribed, even when you feel better, unless your doctor advises a change. [1,2]

## Keep one current list

Write down the name, strength, dose, and timing of each medicine. Include allergies and the vitamins, herbal products, and other medicines you use. Bring the list to appointments and show it to every professional involved in your care. After a hospital stay or prescription change, ask which older instructions should be replaced. An updated list helps avoid confusion between different versions of your plan. [1,3]

## Ask about missed doses

There is no single missed-dose rule that fits every medicine. Ask your pharmacist what to do if you miss a dose of each medicine. Keep the instructions with your list. Do not take an extra dose simply to catch up. If you are unsure whether you already took a dose, seek advice rather than guessing. Tell the team if the schedule regularly clashes with meals, work, or sleep. [1]

## Choose a useful reminder

A phone alarm, calendar, or written checklist may help you remember a dose. Ask your pharmacist whether a pill organizer is suitable, since storage requirements differ. The best reminder is one you can use consistently. If a relative helps, agree on who records each dose so two people do not unknowingly give the same medicine. Keep medicines safely away from children. [1]

## Plan before supplies run out

Count how much medicine remains and note when you need a refill. Check clinic hours and the steps for renewing a prescription. Tell your team early if cost or availability makes it hard to continue treatment. Ask about safe options instead of borrowing someone else’s pills or taking smaller doses to stretch a supply. Keep the packaging so names and instructions remain available. [4]

## Report a problem clearly

If you think a medicine is causing a problem, describe what happened and when it began. Note whether a dose or prescription recently changed. Ask which side effects need prompt advice and which need emergency care. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, or another serious reaction needs urgent attention. A diary can help the discussion, but must not delay urgent care.

## Leave with a clear plan

Before leaving the clinic or pharmacy, repeat the instructions in your own words. Ask about food, products to avoid, and whom to contact with questions. Keep a clear written plan rather than relying on memory.

## References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Taking control of your medications. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/cardiac-rehab/managing-your-medicines/taking-control-of-your-medicines

2. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Managing your medications. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/cardiac-rehab/managing-your-medicines

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Taking multiple medicines safely. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000883.htm

4. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Medicine safety — filling your prescription. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000766.htm

**Cardiac Rehabilitation Unit**
Cardiac Center · Bicol Medical Center
3rd Floor, 5-Storey Building · BMC Road, Concepcion Pequeña
Naga City, Camarines Sur 4400
**0917-155-7163** · bmccardiaccenter@gmail.com
Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
https://jusanmisolas.github.io/bmccare/